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NATIONAL COORDINATING CENTER
INSTITUTE FOR COMMUNITY INCLUSION, UMass Boston



Accreditation of Inclusive Postsecondary Education Programs: How to Create Your Plan

February 6, 2024

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Overview

- How Accreditation Benefits Students and Our Programs
- A Brief Overview of the Accreditation Process
- Practicalities of Applying the Standards
- Creating a Plan for Your Program with Accreditation Tools
- Moderated Q & A

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March 05, 2024

Ensuring Quality Programs for Students With Intellectual Disabilities

An emerging accreditor aims to set standards for evaluating the growing number of programs for students long underserved in higher education.

By Amy Denny



As demand continues to grow for colleges and universities to serve students with intellectual disabilities, a recently formed accreditation board is focused on ensuring that programs meet quality standards.

Read to Google

Click using the AI

Why this will 10



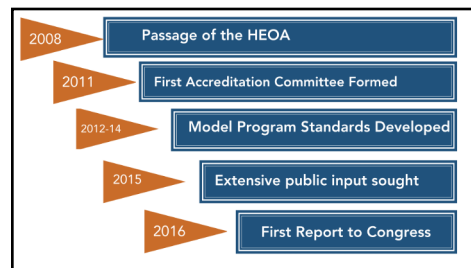

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Questions that Inform Accreditation

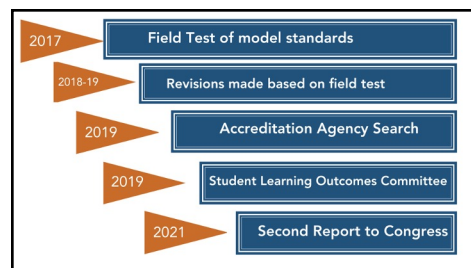
1. Do students complete the program successfully and earn the credential?
2. Does the program provide the enrolled students with the supports needed to be successful during the program?
3. Do students and families receive what they expected to receive before, during, and after the program?
4. Does the college and university support students in the program?
5. Does the program provide exiting students with the supports needed to be successful in their next step in employment or further education?



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2021 - 2025 NCC AWG charge – To develop and pilot a accreditation process for five program sites.



Western Carolina University UP Program (first pilot) received accreditation in 2023.



UCCS and VCU will complete the process in 2024.

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WCU Stories

Campus Life | Innovation | Community | Multimedia | For the Media

UP Program becomes first in country to be accredited

WCU Stories | May 9, 2023



About the Blog

Western Carolina University is located in the beautiful Southern Appalachian mountains of Caldwell County, North Carolina. Our dedicated faculty and staff are committed to providing students exceptional learning and research opportunities. Please feel free to contact us for more information. Email: info@wcu.edu or call 828.255.1234.

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Why is the accreditation of our programs important?

1. Our students deserve accredited programs. Programs that have been reviewed by our peers and represent the quality programming that we all want to provide.
2. Completing the accreditation process helps us improve our practices in student learning and achievement.
3. Seeking accreditation demonstrates a tangible commitment to program quality improvement and assurance.



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Benefits

1. Students know that programs have offerings, practices, and policies in place for their success.
2. Students and families have a way to compare programs which in turn will help them pursue the best fit.
3. Programs have a way to demonstrate our alignment with the current, best practices in IPSE.
4. Programs solidify our program on the campus through commitment and engagement from leadership.



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Applying the Standards to Our Programs



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Accreditation Standard Areas

 MISSION	 STUDENT ACHIEVEMENT	 CURRICULUM	 FACULTY	 FACILITY, EQUIPMENT AND SUPPLY
 ADMINISTRATIVE AND FISCAL CAPACITY	 STUDENT SERVICES	 LENGTH AND STRUCTURE OF PROGRAM/OF STUDY	 STUDENT COMPLAINTS	 PROGRAM DEVELOPMENT, PLANNING, AND REVIEW



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10 Standard Areas and 38 Standards

- Standard
- Guidance
- Required for Review (e.g., evidence)



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Mission Standard 1

The program has a written mission statement that is consistent with the Higher Education Act (HEA) requirements that the program is a "degree, certificate, or non-degree program at an accredited institution that is designed to support students with intellectual disabilities (ID) who are seeking to continue academic, career and technical, and independent living instruction" to obtain competitive integrated employment (CIE).



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Guidance for Mission Standard 1

The mission statement must be consistent with the statutory and regulatory requirements in the HEA. However, a mission statement is not required to explicitly include the language from the definition of a "student with an intellectual disability" and the definition of a "Comprehensive Transition and Postsecondary Program for Students with Intellectual Disabilities" (CTP) in the HEA. The intent of this standard is to ensure that the mission standard aligns with the law and does not contradict it. For instance, the HEA states that programs must serve students with ID. A mission statement that affirms that the program serves students with a variety of disabilities would be contradictory to the intent and language in the HEA. See glossary for CTP, ID, and CIE definitions.

The term "gainful employment" is used in the CTP definition in HEA. However, the US Department of Education (ED) no longer considers CTPs to be gainful employment programs. The updated term "competitive integrated employment" is used instead, as it is defined in the Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act (WIOA).

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Required for Review (Evidence)

- Provide the mission statement.
- Describe how the mission aligns to the HEA ID and CTP definitions.
 - Provide documentation that the institution is accredited, including the name of the recognized accrediting agency that has accredited the institution.
 - Include the weblink to the institution's accreditation or institutional assessment page.



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Accreditation Process



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Key Concepts



Weave



Self-Study



Peer Reviews



Site Visit

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Tips for Pacing the Self-Study

- Pace a standard or two per week and map that out with others.
- Use the guidance manual and tools to help organize evidence.
- Write the narratives in WEAVE and involve key staff for support.
- Use tables provided as that will decrease narrative length.
- Ask less familiar staff to review self-study and narratives.



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Mapping Out Self-Study Week-by-Week

		2 weeks	2 weeks		
					
MISSION	STUDENT ACHIEVEMENT	CURRICULUM	FACULTY	FACULTY EQUIPMENT AND SUPPLY	
					
ADMINISTRATIVE AND FISCAL CAPACITY	STUDENT SERVICES	LENGTH AND STRUCTURE OF PROGRAM OF STUDY	STUDENT COMPLAINTS	PROGRAM DEVELOPMENT, PLANNING, AND REVIEW	

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Key Roles

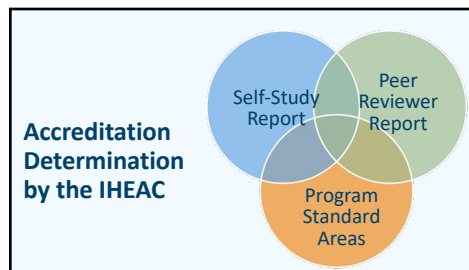


-  NCC Accreditation Workgroup
-  Peer Reviewers
-  IHEAC Liaisons
-  Inclusive Higher Education Accreditation Council Board Members

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IHEA COUNCIL

The Inclusive Higher Education Accreditation Council is an accrediting agency for college and university programs for students with intellectual disability.

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About the Council

The Inclusive Higher Education Accreditation Council (IHEAC) is an independent accrediting agency for college and university programs that serve students with ID. The IHEAC aims to promote standards-based quality programming for students with ID across varied colleges and universities. The agency is approved as a 501(c)(3) under Section 501(c)(3) of the U.S. Internal Revenue Code.

Program Accreditation Standards

The Inclusive Higher Education Accreditation Council (IHEAC) is designed to help programs ensure that they meet quality assurance standards in the field of inclusive higher education. The standards address key areas of college and university programming related to student outcomes and educational supports. Programs that become accredited demonstrate a level of quality programming for students with ID. Learn more about the standards and how your program can get prepared for accreditation.

- Transition Accreditation Standards, Guidelines and Review Requirements
- Guide for Programs for Student Accreditation

Quality Programs are Vital to Student Success

Program accreditation provides an opportunity to demonstrate quality education and programming. Accreditation also provides legitimacy for programs that meet the standards and guidelines for colleges and universities considering enrolling quality programs for students with intellectual disability (ID). In addition, programs can show how they support student success through completion and graduation rates.

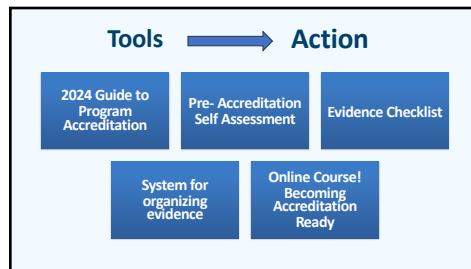
Contact us for more information about IHEAC

[Get A Quote](#)

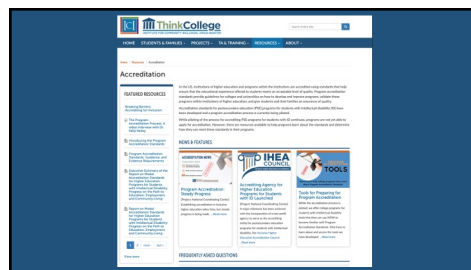
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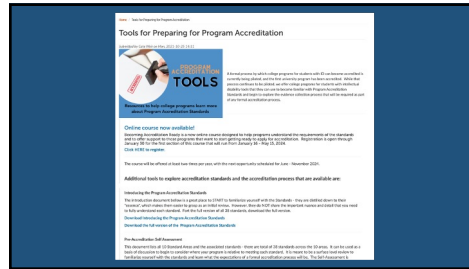
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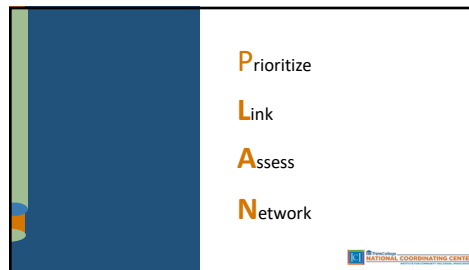
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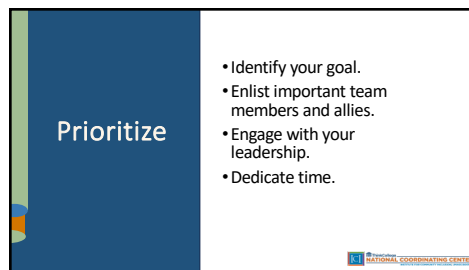
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Link

- Program practices to standard areas.
- Recognize existing sources of data and information.
- Pinpoint available resources.

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Assess

- Create a timeline.
- Conduct the Pre-Accreditation Self-Assessment.
- Determine areas of strength and areas of need.

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PROGRAM ACCREDITATION STANDARDS FOR
Higher Education Programs for Students with Intellectual Disability
Program Pre-accreditation Self-Assessment Tool

Program Name: _____ Date: _____

Staff participating: _____

Get Acquainted. Be prepared to make the program staff to high expectations of the Program Accreditation Standards. These are the standards that the program will be held to. The standards are not a checklist of items to be completed. They are a guide to the standards that the program will be held to. The standards are not a checklist of items to be completed. They are a guide to the standards that the program will be held to.

Get Ready. Meet with your college program team to familiarize yourself with each standard. Review policies and procedures that relate to each standard. Make a list of the standards that you will be responsible for. Make a list of the standards that you will be responsible for. Make a list of the standards that you will be responsible for.

Get Started. Make a plan to begin the self-assessment process. Make a plan to begin the self-assessment process. Make a plan to begin the self-assessment process.

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Evidence Checklist					
Copy of Accreditation Standards: Evidence Checklist					
File Edit View Insert Format Data Tools Extensions Help					
Standard Area 2: Student Achievement					
1	A	B	C	D	E
2	Standard Area 2: Student Achievement	Evidence collected	Evidence available	Program Self Check	Notes
3	Student Achievement Standard 1				
4	The program has established a Satisfactory Academic Progress (SAP) policy that includes criteria for evaluating student progress in academics, socialization, independent living and career development, and the impact of such evaluation on student achievement towards program completion. The program specifies how students' advance through a full course of study and maintain satisfactory academic progress.				
5	Copy of the ILE's Satisfactory Academic Progress Policy, with discussion of how it is applied to program students	☐	☐	☐	☐
6	Copy of the program's Satisfactory Academic Progress Policy, including how SAP is measured in all areas of the program's course of study (academics)	☐	☐	☐	☐

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Network

- Connect with colleagues.
- Discuss specific practices.
- Enroll in the online course.



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New Course!

Becoming Accreditation Ready

- Seeking interested folks to enroll and complete 11 asynchronous learning modules.
- Cohort model.
- Participate in an online cohort discussion if desired.
- Complete feedback surveys about your experience with the online-course.

Deadline Extended!

Enroll by February 16

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Contact us:

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- Martha Mock mmock@ur.rochester.edu

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